

Đờn ca tài tử: Memory & Intimacy



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Statement of Intent

“Design interface(s) to reignite interest in đồn ca tài tử in young people.”

This project explores how đồn ca tài tử, a traditional form of Southern Vietnamese music, can become a way to reconnect younger generations with their cultural roots. Instead of focusing on preserving the genre exactly as it was, the project looks at how we might use music and memory to spark personal reflection and emotional connection.

The outcome will be a “memory interface”, a design that uses sound, type, and interaction to invite users to slow down and listen. It aims to create a space that feels intimate, where people can reflect on what might be lost if these cultural forms are forgotten. Rather than fully critiquing or celebrating the genre, the project sits somewhere in between: asking questions, sparking curiosity, and creating room for emotional storytelling.

The target audience is young Vietnamese people, especially those living in cities or abroad, who may feel disconnected from traditions like đồn ca tài tử. By combining traditional sounds with contemporary design tools, this project hopes to present the genre in a new light. It is less about nostalgia, more about meaningful connection.

Design Analysis



Problem
and Proposition

A Disconnected Generation



Young people today, especially those in cities, feel disconnected from traditional music like *đờn ca tài tử*. The genre is often seen as old-fashioned, irrelevant, or “for grandparents.” It’s usually presented in ways that feel distant, formal, or hard to relate to, losing the emotional connection it once had in everyday life.

A Memory Interface to Reconnect



My project aims to create an interactive memory interface that uses sound, type, and storytelling to help younger audiences experience *đờn ca tài tử* in a personal and emotional way. It’s not about saving or modernizing the genre, but about building a quiet space where people can reflect, feel, and connect with cultural memory.

Research and Context



Generational Disconnect

In Mekong delta provinces, the audience of *đờn ca tài tử* is *cô, chú* (aunties and uncles). **This emphasizes the disconnect between the generations.**

* Images sourced from my hometown.



Outdated Aesthetic

Many design choices further alienates the younger generation. This aesthetic is not wrong per se, but it creates friction for the youth who might otherwise be interested.

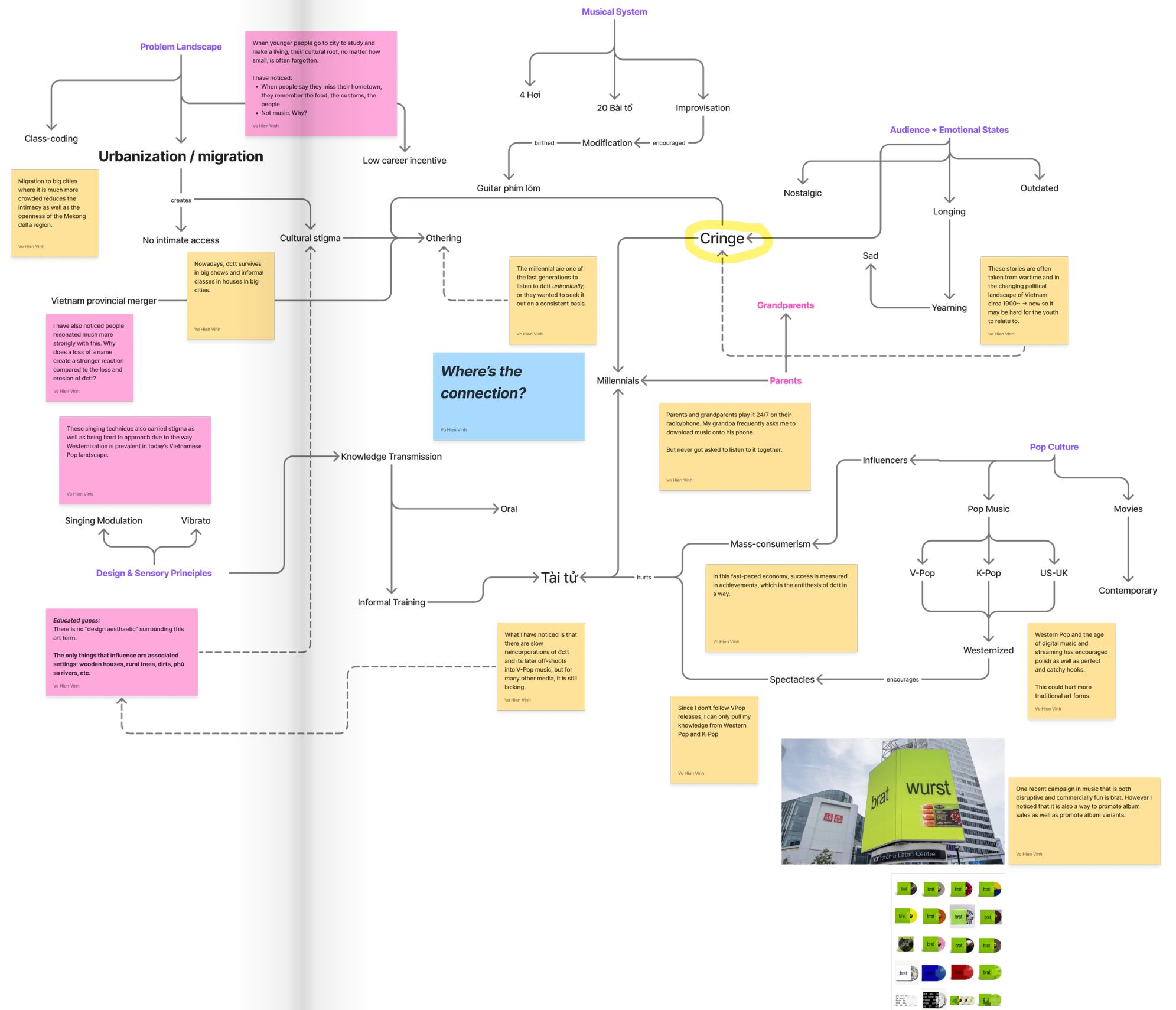
Preliminary Insight

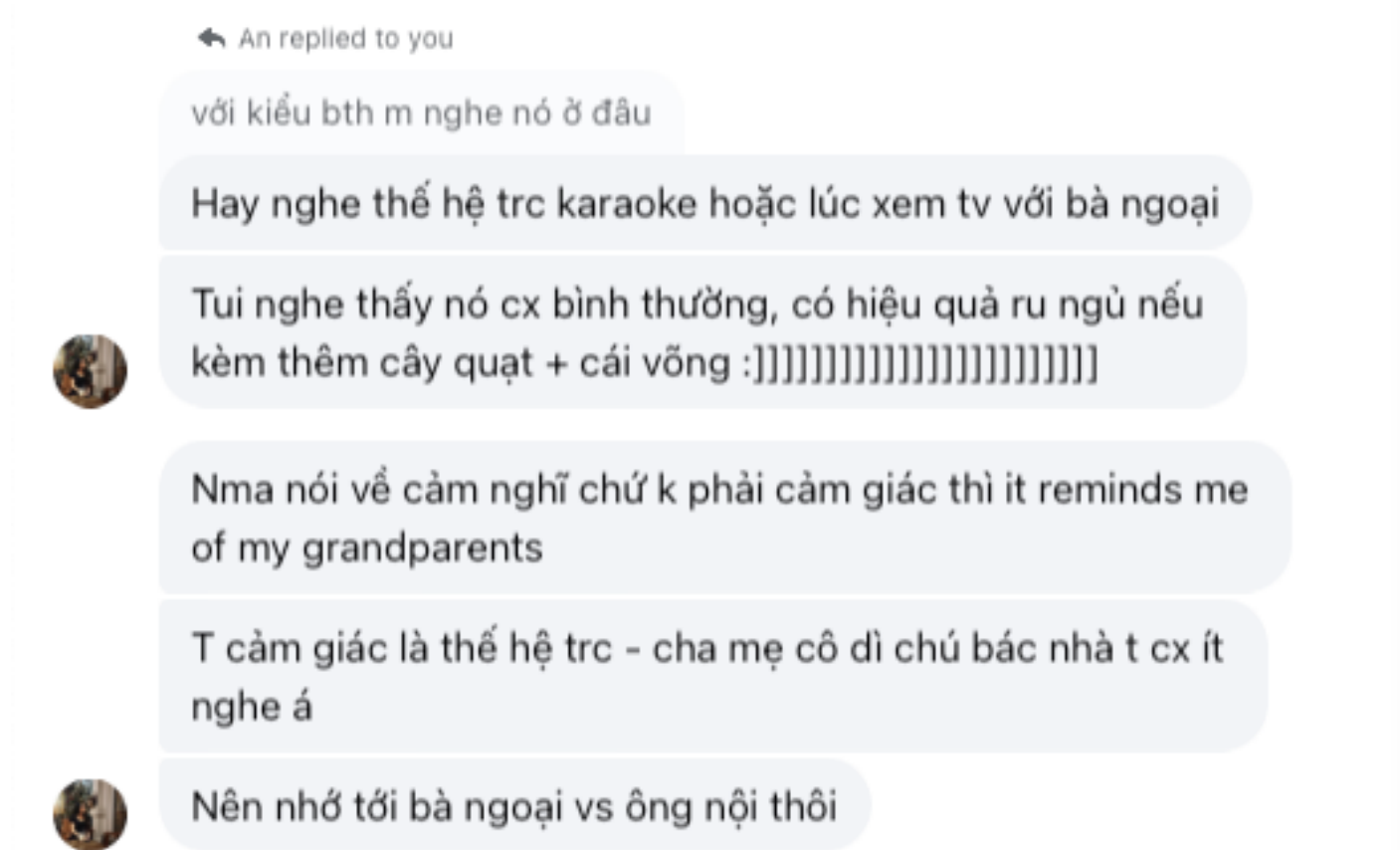
In the Mekong Delta, đờn ca tài tử remains culturally alive, but mostly among older generations.

Its current visual and performance aesthetics, while authentic, often feel outdated or inaccessible to younger audiences. This creates a gap not just in age, but in emotional and aesthetic language, where even those curious about the genre feel distanced by how it's presented. There's an opportunity to bridge this disconnect by rethinking how the genre is visually communicated.

Further Research

I created a more general mapping on the topic.
This has allowed me to gather more insights on pop culture and digital intimacy.





I interviewed my friends who are from the Mekong Delta, one thing that I could tap into was **their mention of parents and grandparents who are associated with the genre.**



Pop Culture and Digital Intimacy

While there are signs of *đờn ca tài tử* and its offshoots subtly reappearing in V-Pop, this reintegration is still rare across other media. In contrast, mainstream pop culture, shaped by streaming platforms, social media, and global music trends, prioritizes perfection, polish, and instant appeal. Campaigns like *brat* are bold and disruptive but ultimately function as marketing tools, reinforcing a fast-paced, high-output model of intimacy built on parasocial relationships and performative connection. This stands in stark contrast to the slow, relational nature of *đờn ca tài tử*, where emotion is built through time, presence, and shared space.

What's needed?



A bridge.

Design Approach

Use familiar, emotionally resonant imagery, such as everyday objects tied to parents, as entry points into the world of *đờn ca tài tử*. These visuals act as memory triggers, working alongside sound and ambient interaction to create a soft, reflective experience.

Instead of positioning *đờn ca tài tử* as a distant form, it is reintroduced through novel touchpoints, ones that feel more native to younger audiences, yet still grounded in warmth and memory. The aim is not to modernize the genre through trend, but to quietly reframe it as something deeply personal and worth revisiting.

Project Positioning



The project would be **speculative** and **cultural blending**.

This project is important to me because it helps me reconnect with my cultural roots and reflect on where I come from. It allows me to grow as a designer by exploring emotional storytelling and interaction.

On a societal scale, it offers a way for younger generations to engage with their elders and rediscover a fading cultural form. In the context of the 2025 Provincial Merge, it speaks to shared themes of identity, memory, and quiet loss—something many people can relate to.

Persona



Lý Diên Hy

Age: 22

Occupation: University student (Marketing major)

Location: Ho Chi Minh City, originally from Cần Thơ

Digital Habits: Locket, Instagram, and TikTok; follows a blend of mainstream and indie, niche aesthetics.

“As a young Vietnamese design student who feels disconnected from his cultural roots, I want to experience *đờn ca tài tử* in a way that feels personal and emotionally relevant, so I can better understand and reconnect with my heritage.”

Motivations

To experience cultural heritage without it feeling forced, stiff, or overly formal

To find quiet, reflective moments in contrast to his fast-paced digital life

Needs

Wants to reconnect with his cultural identity in a way that feels relevant to his life now

Seeks deeper emotional experiences beyond fast-scrolling content

Craves quiet, personal moments of reflection in his busy academic life

Frustrations

Feels guilty about not knowing more about his roots, but doesn't know where to start

Feels that traditional music is beautiful but inaccessible or “not meant for people like him”

Young university students are important to this project because they represent the generation most affected by cultural disconnect, curious about their roots but lacking meaningful access points.

By designing for them, the project aims to reintroduce *đờn ca tài tử* in a way that feels personal, emotionally relevant, and digitally native, creating space for reflection, reconnection, and intergenerational dialogue.

Case Study #1



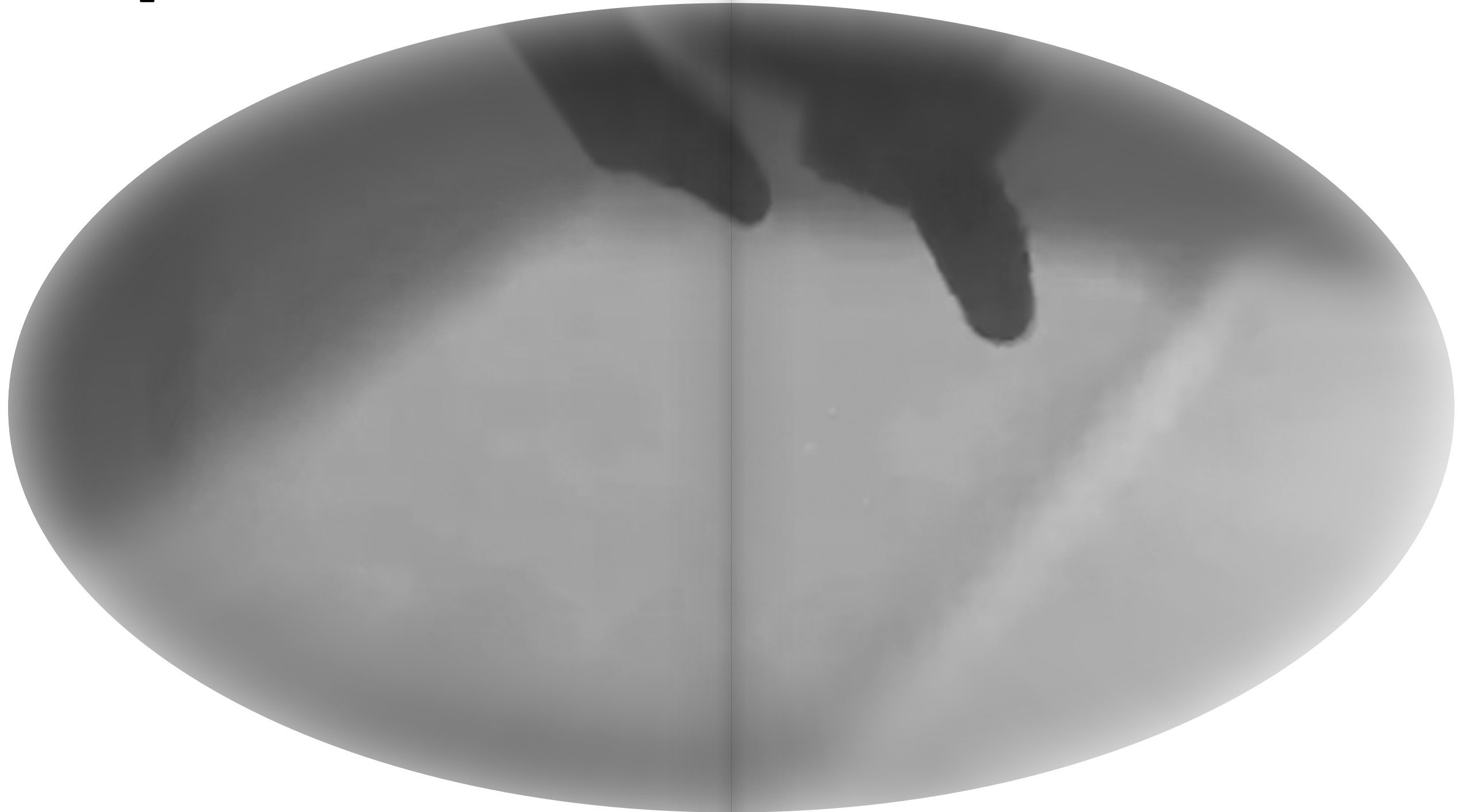
“Đờn ca tài tử Nam Bộ – Di sản tỏa sáng” (Southern Đờn Ca Tài Tử – A Radiant Heritage) represents large-scale, government-led efforts to showcase the genre as a valued cultural heritage. These programs feature elaborate staging, coordinated performances, and formal recognition ceremonies. While they help bring attention to the genre, the format tends to cater to urban audiences and more mature viewers. The emphasis on spectacle can shift the focus away from the informal, community-based atmosphere where đờn ca tài tử originally thrived.

Case Study #2



This performance in Vĩnh Long was part of my field research. I travelled here to observe how *đờn ca tài tử* is presented in a more familiar, home-like setting. The use of everyday objects, wooden furniture, altar cabinets, and ceramic wares, creates a strong sense of place and cultural warmth. Experiencing it firsthand helped me understand how intimacy is embedded in the music, and how space and setting contribute to emotional connection. This serves as a valuable contrast to larger, stage-based performances.

Initial Development



Narrative,
Scenarios & Ideas

Design Narrative

I aim to create a intimate space, one that invites users to slow down, listen, and reflect.

The tone is gentle, sitting somewhere between nostalgia and distance. It's about evoking a feeling of quiet recognition, allowing people to engage with *đờn ca tài tử* not through explanation, but through atmosphere. The experience is designed to feel unhurried, like stumbling across an old memory you didn't know you missed.

Scenarios

Before

The user has no strong attachment or understanding of *đờn ca tài tử*. They might associate it with old age, provincial culture, or family they no longer live near. Emotionally, they're distanced, apathetic, amused, or slightly curious.

During

The user encounters the interface: a physical or digital object with tactile, visual, and aural layers. They touch, flip, listen, scroll, each gesture creates new configurations, suggesting memory fragments or emotions. They recognize sounds, objects, or references tied to home, family, or forgotten rituals.

After

The user walks away not with a conclusion, but with a lingering sensation: "I haven't thought about that in a long time." They may seek to ask a grandparent about a song, or re-listen with new ears. The experience becomes a memory itself, creating a soft imprint and planting a seed of curiosity.

Ideas

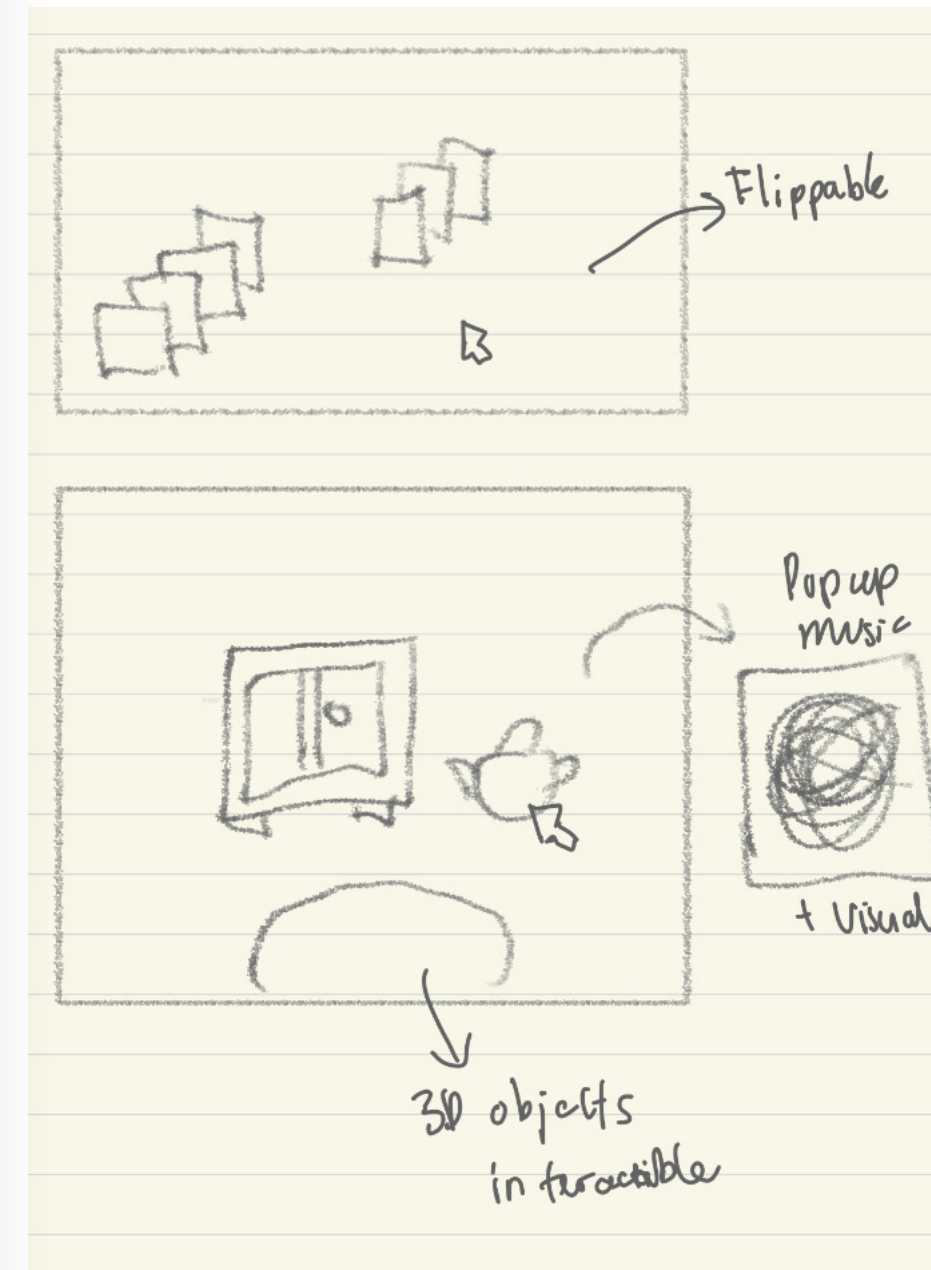
Moodboard



A combination of clean typography, creative color palettes, and textural elements drives the visual direction. The references range from minimal, abstract forms to playful, nostalgic graphics, offering a diverse set of inspirations that balance clarity with personality.



Sketches



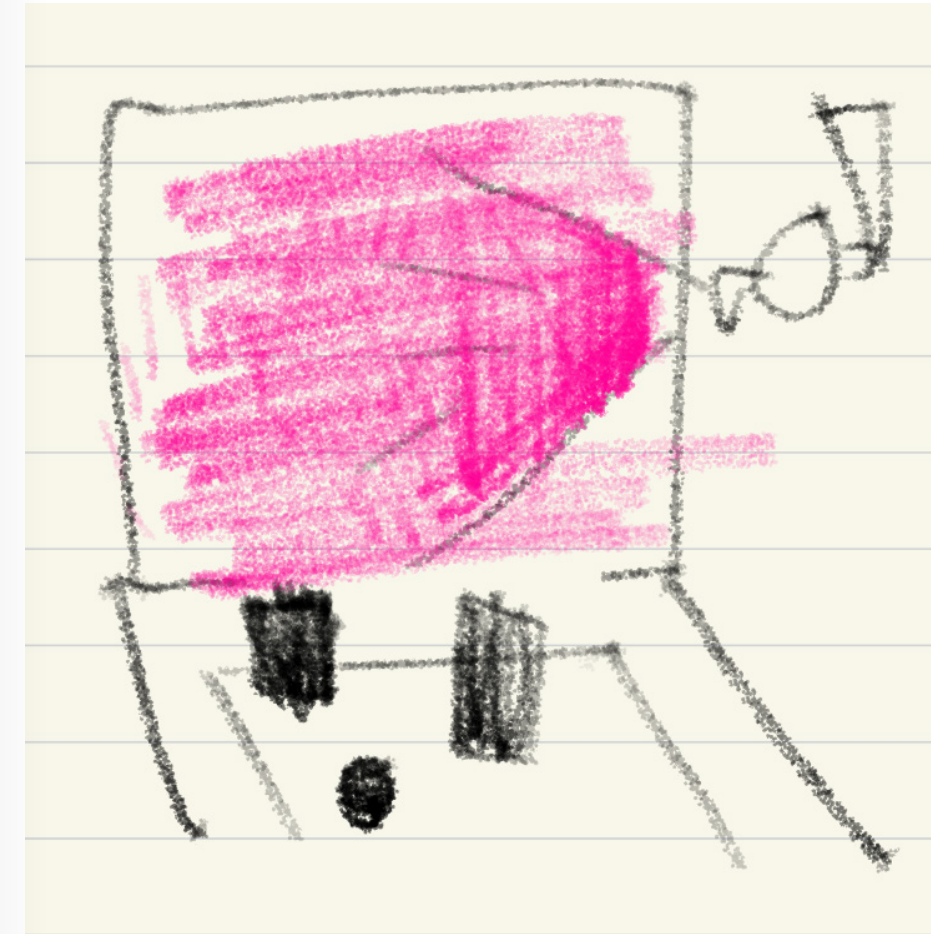
The interface is designed to support extended scrolling experiences enriched with elegant, emotive animations. By incorporating skeuomorphic design and culturally meaningful visuals, the project aims to create a sense of tactile familiarity, bridging digital interaction with memory and feeling.

Moodboard



Interactive installation art offers a compelling physical experience that draws audiences in. Its novelty and sensory engagement redefine how we perceive and interact with creative works. This approach opens up new possibilities for expressing ideas in more immersive and tangible ways.

Sketches and Inspirations



This concept explores how cultural objects can serve as tools for interaction. When touched, these objects will trigger dynamic visual projections (pink in sketch, not final) and generate sound through an integrated audio system. The experience will blend visual, auditory, and tactile elements, creating a multi-sensory narrative rooted in cultural symbolism.



Greenwich

▼ HAL Timezone ▼ Regular Size 30px —○— OT Features ▼

As the United Kingdom developed into an advanced maritime nation, British mariners kept at least one chronometer on GMT to calculate their longitude from the Greenwich meridian, which was considered to have longitude zero degrees, by a convention adopted in the International Meridian Conference of 1884. Synchronisation of the chronometer on GMT did not affect shipboard time, which was still solar time. But this practice, combined with mariners from other nations drawing from Nevil Maskelyne’s method of lunar distances based on observations at Greenwich, led to GMT being used worldwide as a standard time independent of location. Most time zones were based upon GMT, as an offset of a number of hours. Greenwich Mean Time was adopted across the island of Great Britain by the Railway Clearing House in 1847 and by almost all railway companies by the following year, from which the term “railway time” is derived. It was gradually adopted for other purposes, but a legal case in 1858 held “local mean time” to be the official time.

Unclaimed Property Site Technology is a glittering lure. So there’s nothing you can do for a damsel in distress?

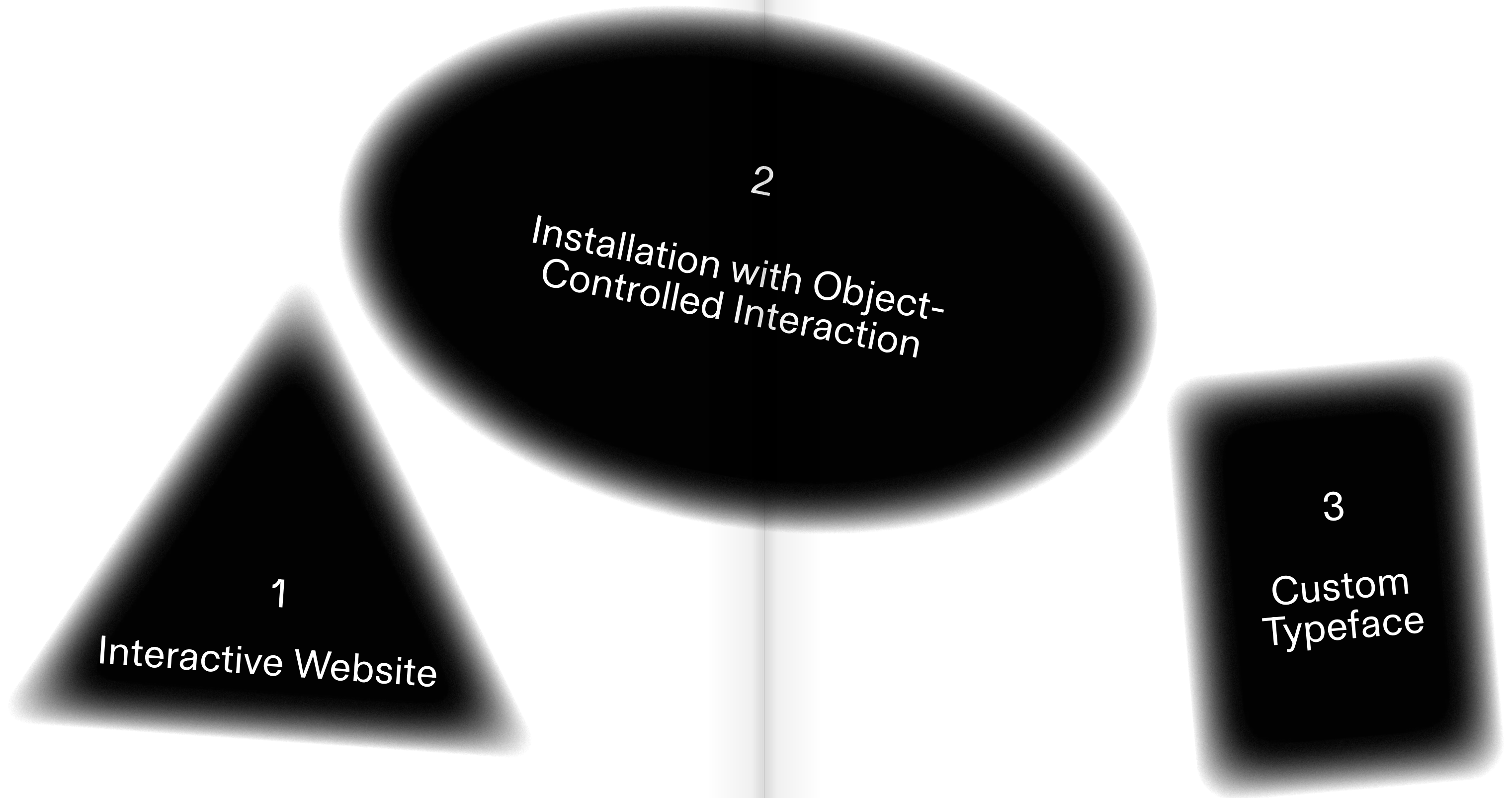
Rationale and Stragety

Many serif fonts I wanted to use were not available in Vietnamese. After some research, I realized that a common fallback, like Times New Roman, is often seen in Vietnam as “un-modern” or overly formal.

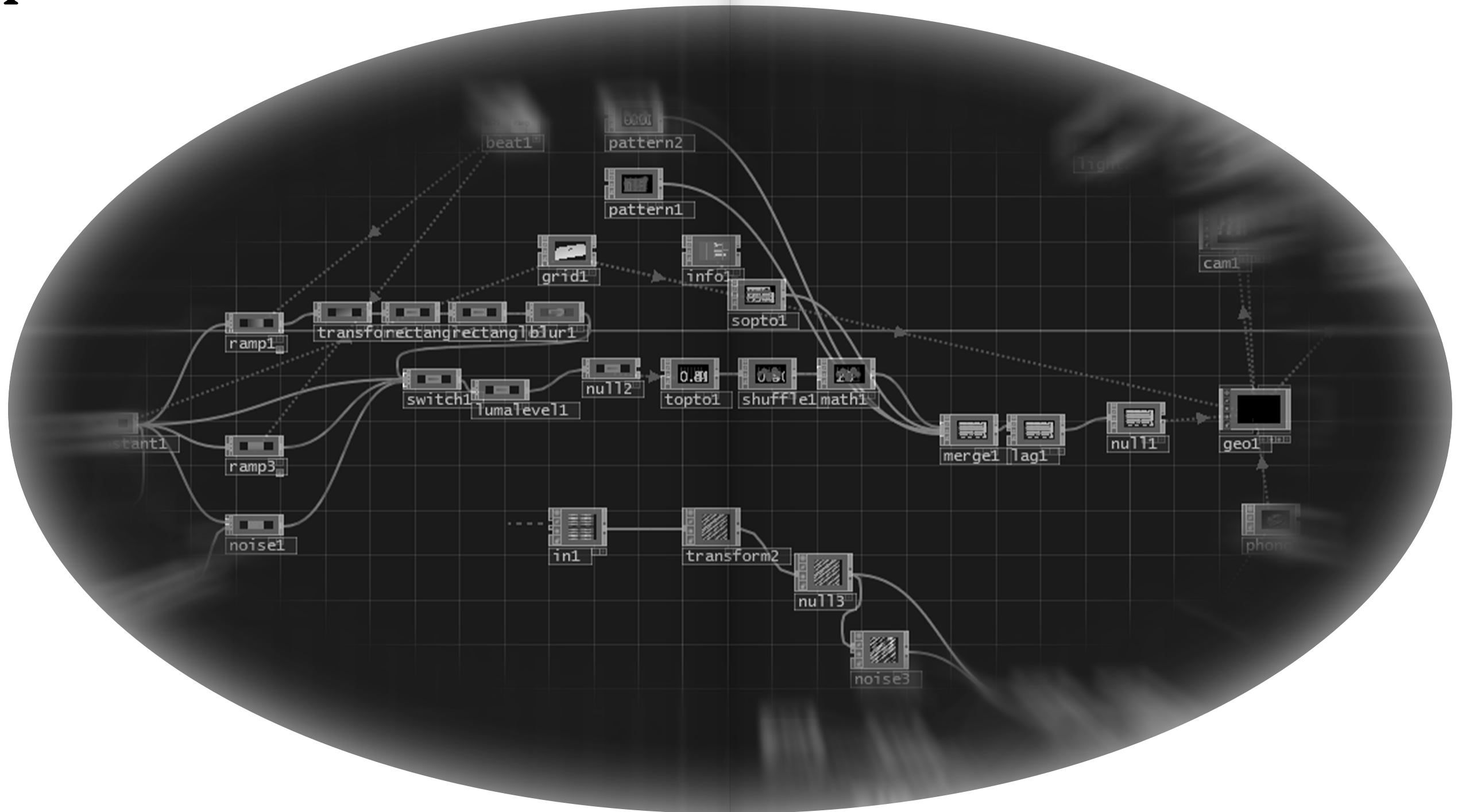
To address this, I propose designing a custom typeface inspired by the structure of Times New Roman, but with a warmer tone and more personality. By doing so, I aim to preserve the familiarity of a classic serif while making it feel contemporary and approachable. Just as đờn ca tài tử blends classical rigor with personal emotion, this typeface aims to honor formal typographic roots while inviting a more tender, expressive tone.

This strategy works on two levels: it resonates with older generations through its recognizable form, while its refreshed design can subtly appeal to younger audiences looking for something new.

Expected Outcomes



Practical Requirements



Risk
Management

Figma

Glyphs

TouchDesigner

p5.js

Makey Makey

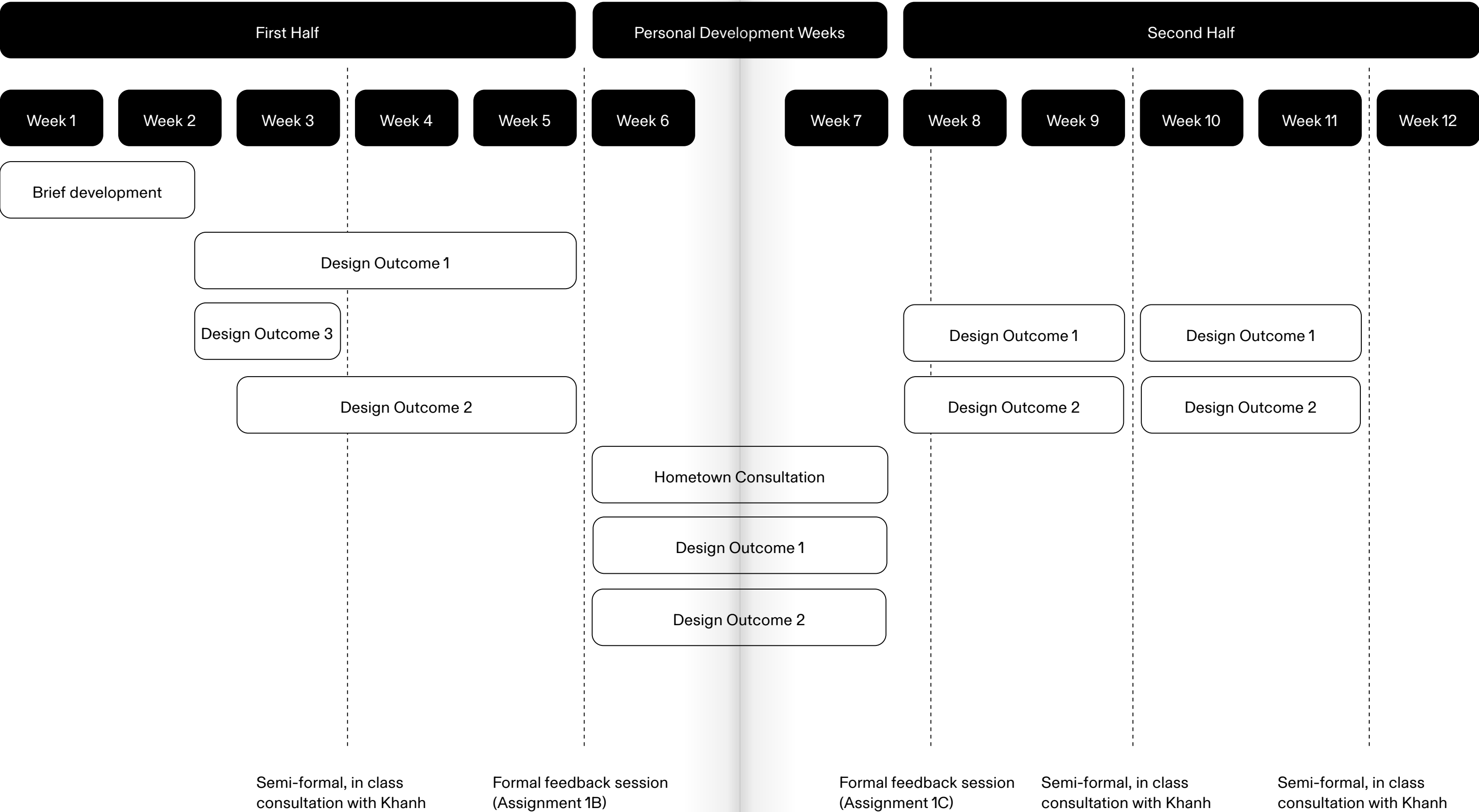
Sourcing real objects

Access to DCTT archive

Risk Management

Risk	Mid-semester travel home for interviews and family consultation could delay production.	Misrepresenting or oversimplifying a traditional genre may cause unintended disrespect or erasure.	Trying to create both physical and digital outcomes may stretch time and energy thin.	Users may not feel the same emotional attachment to đồn ca tài tử or family memory.
	Medium		High	Low
Mitigation	Begin design ideation early; front-load digital prototyping. Use remote interviews and existing recordings to fill early-stage gaps.	Use first-person connection (family, local context), consult musicians or cultural mentors mid-way, and avoid aestheticization without narrative.	Prioritize one main format (e.g. interactive microsite), then treat others as secondary or modular.	Frame the experience around universal feelings rather than cultural specificity alone. Use sound, pacing, and tone to create an emotional atmosphere.
		Medium		

Schedule



References

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